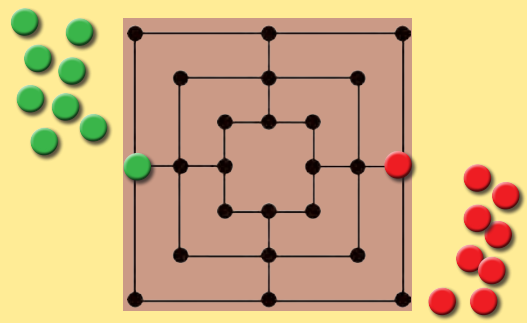
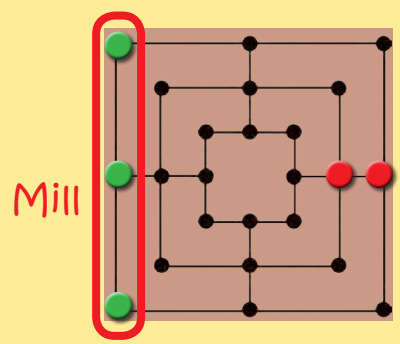
31. Give your Mind a Workout!

The proverb 'A sound mind in a sound body' simply means that one's body and mind should both be kept fit and healthy. We need a healthy diet and proper exercise to keep our body fit. What do we do to exercise our mind ? The answer is quite simple. Just as we 'work out' or play games for physical exercise, we can use puzzles, riddles, board games, jokes, etc. to exercise our mind. Let us look at some interesting examples of games, puzzles, riddles and fun facts.

Nine Men's Morris

This game is played with two players. Each player has nine pieces, one set black, one set white. You may simply draw the board as shown alongside and use buttons, beads, seeds, etc. as pieces. The players take turns to place their pieces (men) in the empty spots, one at a time. If you are able to place three 'men' in a row or column, you form a 'mill'. Then you can remove one of your opponent's men. You cannot remove men in your opponent's mill, unless he/she has no other men left on the board.



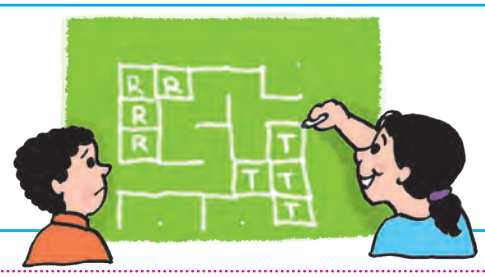


Once you have placed all your men on the board, you can start moving them only to an adjacent empty spot.

If you have only three men left, they can 'fly', that is, they can move to any vacant spot on the board.

If a player has less than three men left, or is unable to make a move, he/she loses the game!

Find out how to play other simpler games like 'tic-tac-toe', 'dots and boxes', etc. and also other board games. You can also invent your own board games.



A Mathemagic Trick :

Take any three-digit number in which the first and the last digits differ by two or more. For example, 145.

Write the number in reverse order, which is 541.

Now subtract the smaller of the two numbers from the bigger one. (541-145)

The difference is 396.

Now reverse this number, you get 693.

Add these two numbers.

The result is 1089.

No matter which three-digit number you start with, the result is always 1089 !

Try this trick with your friends or family members and surprise them by telling the answer yourself !

Find other tricks with numbers with the help of your parents, teachers or from the internet !

A Puzzle :

Pintu invited ten of his friends for a birthday party. He had 10 pencils in a box. He gave each of his friends 1 pencil as a gift. After that, there was one pencil in the box. How did that happen ? Explain.

Possible explanations : 1. Along with the pencil, Pintu gave the box to one of his friends. (That is why the pencil in the box.) 2. One of the friends forgot to take the pencil. So, Pintu put it back in the box.

Find more such puzzles / riddles from other books, magazines or from the internet.

Jokes :

Teacher : Neena Aunty gave you and your younger sister a guava and asked you to share it equally. How much of the guava will you get ?

Ananya : All of it ! My younger sister doesn't like guavas.

Teacher : Saurav, tell me, who makes changes in his environment ?

Saurav : Sorry, Madam, but I didn't do anything !

Find other jokes related to your school subject from sources like magazines, books or the internet.